



Gendered Organizations: Progress and Prospects

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Abstract

In this paper, we explore the context for the emergence of a theory of gendered organizations and define the basic features of the approach, noting the explosion of scholarship in the area and the now firmly established trend toward understanding gender, race, class, and sexuality as aspects of social structures. We focus on three of the most important emerging areas in research on gendered organizations: the study of intersectionality, the increasing emphasis on the importance of organizational context, and the exploration of mechanisms for organizational change. We conclude by briefly noting prospects for the further development of research on gendered organizations.

The appearance, in 1990, of Joan Acker's *Hierarchies, Jobs, Bodies: A Theory of Gendered Organizations* marked a fundamental paradigm shift in the study of gender, work, and organizations. Although as with most such theoretical developments, the precursors of this change had been appearing in the literature in bits and pieces for some time (e.g., Cockburn 1983, 1985; Ferguson 1984; Game and Pringle 1984; Pringle 1989), Acker's article was the first to synthesize these insights into a coherent whole and offer a systematic framework for understanding the gendering of organizations and occupations. In what must now be one of the most often quoted passages in the field, Acker (1990, 146) wrote that to say an organization is gendered means 'that advantage and disadvantage, exploitation and control, action and emotion, meaning and identity are patterned through and in terms of a distinction between male and female, masculine and feminine'. In making this claim, Acker moved gender from the realm of the individual to that of the structure – organizations and occupations themselves could be said to have 'gender'.

Almost 20 years later, it is difficult to overestimate the importance of this insight. In a search using Google Scholar, we found a total of 88 articles or books with the word 'gendered' in the title from the earliest date tracked by the database through 1989. Most of these pieces refer to gender at the individual level, as in 'gendered selves', or 'feminine gendered subjects' (the comparable number for the use of 'gendered' at any point in the article

is 2,730 for this period). From 1990 through mid 2007, 4,660 articles were published with the word 'gendered' in their titles, and by contrast a great number of these refer to gender as an aspect of social structures, as in 'gendered work' or 'gendered space', or 'gendered labor markets' (the comparable number for the use of 'gendered' at any point in the article is 36,300). Although Acker's article was not perhaps the only force behind this change, it clearly marks the moment of a considerable and important shift in the way social scientists think and write about gender.

In this paper, we first briefly explore the context for the emergence of a theory of gendered organizations and define the basic features of the approach. Then, we discuss three emerging areas in research on gendered organizations – the study of intersectionality, the increasing emphasis on the importance of organizational context, and the exploration of mechanisms for organizational change. We close with a brief overview of the prospects for the theory's further development.

Formulating a theory of gendered organizations

In common usage, 'gender' is something that people possess or the way they behave (or should behave); masculinity and femininity are characteristics of individuals. Yet Acker, and the thousands of pieces of academic work that have followed in the wake of the first statement of her theory, suggests we can think of structures themselves as gendered – organizations, she argues, are built on and reproduce gendered inequalities. Through images like a corporate organization's 'ideal manager', who is unencumbered by family responsibilities (or has someone at home to take care of them), able to work almost unlimited hours, and a rational and forceful leader, organizations reflect gendered hierarchies while at the same time perpetuating their existence. Although people bring their own gender to organizations, the jobs they occupy are themselves already gendered. As Cockburn writes: 'People have a gender, which rubs off on the jobs they do. The jobs in turn have a gender character that rubs off on the people that do them' (1988, 38). The gendering of work and work organizations is a dialectical process, albeit one often more determined by structure than the individual.

To understand what is so completely different about this way of viewing work and organizations, a brief review of the paradigms that preceded it are in order. Early research on gender and work, from at least the 1950s through the 1970s, saw the problems of the woman worker as stemming from the woman herself. Sociologist Talcott Parsons (1942), who advanced what he called an analysis of 'sex roles', argued that a woman's personality structure itself made her unfit for the rational, instrumental world of work – women were best suited to serve as 'expressive leaders' in the home, providing comfort and nurturance to their husbands and children. By extension, this meant that women who did work for pay would logically be drawn to nurturing, supportive positions and be far more interested in interpersonal

relationships at work than financial success. At best, women had jobs, not careers. This approach to understanding – and at the same time justifying – inequalities in organizations ultimately came to be called the ‘gender’ approach. Women were in lower status, lower paying positions because they were less committed to work than men and the ‘human capital’ they brought with them was as a consequence less valuable. The problem lay in the women themselves.

In 1977, Kanter’s landmark study, *Men and Women of the Corporation*, dealt a serious blow to the ‘gender’ model. In her study of a large corporation, Kanter demonstrated that gender inequalities lay in the structure of the organization itself. Women had less opportunity, less power, and were found in smaller numbers in important positions than men. Kanter argued that any worker in such a position would lack commitment to their work and would exhibit all of the other negative stereotypes attributed to women workers. A woman manager at the same nominal level as a man, but who nonetheless controlled fewer resources and commanded less support from subordinates, might in fact fulfill the ‘bitchy’ and controlling woman boss role – but so too, Kanter argued, would a man in a similar structural position. Similarly, she suggested, any group in a significant minority in an organization or job (whom she called ‘token’ workers) would experience heightened visibility and face higher barriers to success. Kanter’s theory was explicitly *gender neutral* – she attributed the negative experiences of women at work to their structural positions. Any worker in such a position would behave and be perceived by others in similar ways, regardless of sex (or race, or any other personal characteristic). Kanter’s approach came to be called the ‘job’ model, and studies soon followed that tested the relative merits of the ‘job’ versus ‘gender’ paradigms, usually supporting the former.

Although a welcome change from the perspective that preceded it, the ‘job’ model faced a serious challenge in the 1980s, primarily from a growing body of research on the experiences of men in female-dominated occupations. Although Kanter had argued that the ‘token’ was gender neutral and would be disadvantaged regardless of sex, studies of men in occupations like nursing, librarianship, elementary school teaching, and social work (e.g., Williams 1989, 1995; Zimmer 1988) soon demonstrated that not all tokens were alike. Men in fact benefited from their token status in ways that women in male-dominated occupations did not, riding a ‘glass escalator’ to success (Williams 1992).

But rather than return to a model that sought explanations in workers themselves, researchers began to look to the characteristics of the organizations and jobs in which they did their work. The culturally promulgated image of the ideal manager, for example, means that men always appear to be better candidates for management, even in a female-dominated occupation like nursing. And patterns of homosocial interaction in organizations create situations in which men who are elementary school teachers or floor nurses build networks with men administrators and thus improve

their chances for promotion. Gendered inequalities are built into organizations, a fact that explains men's success regardless of their 'token' status.

This is the guiding premise behind Acker's theory of gendered organizations, an approach that revives the focus on gender, but this time as an aspect of structures, rather than (or more than) individuals. The other essential element of the theory is her multilevel framework for understanding processes of gendering. In her original statement of the theory, Acker offered five levels of analysis (1990), later narrowed that to four (1992), and subsequent research in the area has continued to refine and develop the framework (Britton 2003). In the simplest terms, we can say that organizations and occupations are gendered at the level of culture – we think of particular jobs and organizations in gendered ways – the military 'turns boys into men'. They also reflect and reproduce gender through their policies and practices. For example, assigning women officers in men's prisons to answer phones or supervise women visitors means they rarely acquire the direct experience with inmates that supervisors see as necessary for promotion. Interactions between workers may reproduce inequality – if men socialize with their supervisors outside of work they can increase their visibility and chances for success. Finally, workers themselves may craft their identities in gendered ways through their work. A woman prison officer might think of herself as a 'mother', or a 'babysitter' (Britton 2003). A male nurse could choose to emphasize the physically strenuous aspects of his work to see himself as masculine, as in the geriatric nurse (quoted in Williams 1995), who described himself as a human 'forklift' picking up heavy patients.

The research that has followed in the wake of the original statement of the theory is a diverse and rapidly growing body of literature. Even at this stage, less than two decades on, summarizing it all would be an impossible task. Hence, we have decided to focus on what we see as three important trends in research employing a gendered organizations paradigm. They are the connections between intersectional perspectives and gendered work, the increasing focus on the influence of organizational context, and the exploration of strategies for change.

Intersectionality and gendered organizations

Most research in the gendered organizations tradition has, perhaps not surprisingly, highlighted gender while paying less attention to the ways that work may also be 'raced' or 'sexualized' or 'classed'. Yet, as theorists of intersectionality have long argued (e.g., Hill Collins 1999; Spelman 1998), we know that gender is only separable from these other dimensions of inequality in an analytic sense – we may choose to focus on gender, but the story we tell in doing so is always incomplete. The 'ideal worker' is male, but he is also often white, middle class, and heterosexual. Although not her central focus, in her original statement of a theory of gendered

organizations, Acker left the door open to considering other forms of inequality. She noted, for example, the dominance of norms of heterosexuality in most organizations, and argued that class and gender inequalities are often mutually constitutive. Race she left largely as a question: 'Are racial differences produced by organizational practices as gender differences are?' (1990, 154).

More recently, Acker has further developed her position on the intersections of race, class, and gender, offering the concept of 'inequality regimes', which she defines as 'loosely interrelated practices, processes, actions, and meanings that result in and maintain class, gender, and racial inequalities within particular organizations' (2006, 443). She sees these as 'fluid and changing ... linked to inequality in the surrounding society, its politics, history, and culture' (2006, 443). By conceptualizing occupations and organizations as settings that are built on and reproduce a variety of inequalities, Acker appears to award similar analytic importance to gender, race, and class. Her choice of categories of emphasis is significant, however. Although she observes that sexuality may also be important, she nonetheless argues it is 'not as thoroughly embedded in organizing processes as are gender, race, and class' (2006, 445; for a similar position, see Andersen 2005).

It remains to be seen whether the notion of 'inequality regimes' will become entrenched in the literature, but research using the gendered organizations approach has already begun to demonstrate the ways that dimensions of inequality intersect in organizational logics and in the lives of workers. For example, Trautner (2005), in a study of exotic dancers at four different strip clubs, convincingly demonstrates that the cultures, policies, interactions, and even bodies and identities in these sites are gendered, but also fundamentally classed. Dancers in middle-class clubs practice what she calls 'voyeuristic sexuality', maintaining distance from customers and sculpting their bodies and their performances to fit (white) middle-class norms of gender and sexuality. Dancers in working-class clubs perform (a more racially diverse) 'cheap thrills' sexuality, dressing and dancing in ways that involve much more blatant displays of sexuality. As these women 'do gender' they also 'do class' and 'do sexuality'. But this is more than an individual phenomenon. The policies of the clubs, their décor, rules for other club employees, and approved forms of interaction between dancers and customers reflect the varying class locations of the organizations (for a similar comparative study, see Lerum 2004). Sexuality and class are as embedded in organizational logic as gender – no one aspect can be studied in isolation from the others.

Gendered organizations theorists have focused on race perhaps less than any other aspect of organizational inequality. This is curious, as research on workplace discrimination certainly demonstrates that, to paraphrase Acker (1990), 'advantage and disadvantage, exploitation and control, action and emotion, meaning and identity' in organizations and occupations is

often 'patterned through and in terms of a distinction between' white workers and workers of color. Yet, often race is mentioned as a sidenote in work drawing on the gendered organizations framework (e.g., Trautner 2005; see also Britton 1997); rarely is it a central theme. Whether this is about the general 'whiteness' of the academy or the defensiveness and hence subversion attached to racialized logics in organizations is difficult to determine. There have been some promising exceptions, however. Kennelly (1999), in an analysis of interviews with white employers seeking workers for unskilled positions, finds that they rely heavily on racialized and gendered stereotypes in their thinking about ideal (versus actual) workers. A white woman manager described blacks as 'belligerent' employees prone to challenging management policies; still other employers typified black women – regardless of their actual marital or parental status – as single mothers likely to prioritize children over work. Similarly, Moss and Tilly (1996) found that employers believed black men lacked 'soft skills' such as motivation and the ability to interact easily with customers and coworkers. These studies demonstrate quite clearly that race combines with gender in hiring decisions to bolster inequalities that advantage white workers over workers of color.

Moving beyond the boundaries of white-dominated organizations and occupations, still other research has examined racialized industries and small businesses. Harvey's (2005) work on African American women's entrepreneurship in hair salons is a rich analysis that simultaneously centers multiple aspects of inequality. African American women, like many women drawn to entrepreneurship, find small business ownership attractive because it gives them the ability to balance work and family. Their working-class status means that although their formal skills may be limited, 'doing hair' is a viable option, and the presence of a racialized niche market creates opportunities for success. Similarly, Kang's (2003) study of 'embodied' labor by Korean women in nail salons demonstrates the raced, classed, and gendered expectations encountered by Asian women engaging in 'embodied emotional labor'.

Sexuality has been a much more common focus of research in the gendered organizations tradition. Trautner (2005), discussed above, is obviously one such example, although there are many others (e.g., Collinson and Hearn 1990; Schilt 2006). Ward (2004) in a study that draws directly on a gendered organizations framework, explored the experiences of Latina lesbian workers at *Bienestar*, an AIDS organization that also offered programs for Latina/o gays and lesbians. The very few lesbian staff were marginalized by male workers and managers, but nonetheless many came to believe in the organizational logics that justified this. The organization's focus on (and funding for) HIV/AIDS prevention meant that little emphasis was placed on the needs of lesbians, a fact that over time became enshrined as 'only natural'. Even so, lesbians continued to work at the organization because it was one of the only venues in which Latina lesbians could come

together outside the confines of the racism and heterosexism of the larger society. Ward's study, like so much of the work we have reviewed here, highlights the need to keep multiple aspects of inequality at the center of organizational analysis. This is obvious in an explicitly sexualized and racialized context – like *Bienestar*, or a strip club – but the dimensions of race, class, and sexuality are as fundamental to shaping organizational logics in ordinary organizations as gender.

As we note at the beginning of this section, Acker has suggested the term 'inequality regimes' as a way of shifting the focus of the gendered organizations approach in a way that prioritizes the analysis of intersectionality. The advantage of the approach as she defines it lies in the notion of race, gender, and class inequality as produced by loosely coupled processes whose relationships can and do shift. If the growing research on intersectionality and work has told us anything, it is that notions about race and class come together in complicated and contradictory ways in organizations and often change over time. For example, some studies find that black men may be preferred as workers over women, white or black, in masculinized, blue-collar occupations like policing and prison work (e.g., Britton 1997). Historically, notions about race and class have shifted to shape an image of the 'ideal' domestic worker that now marks black women as too 'uppity' to perform this labor (Hondagneu-Sotelo 2001). Race and class inequality are integral to organizations and occupations, but the processes that produce them and give them salience vary widely in different circumstances.

One problem with the notion of inequality regimes, however, lies in Acker's treatment of sexuality as secondary to class and race. As a growing body of research demonstrates, sexuality is equally embedded, along with gender, in organizational processes. We can see this in the discrimination faced by gay and lesbian workers in organizations (Miller 1999; Ward 2004) but also in the persistence of ideals like the 'office wife', or in the image of the ideal manager as someone who has the stability provided by family, but also access to labor of women in the private sector that ensures his career will proceed uninterrupted. Hence, a more complete notion of inequality regimes would be one that gave equal weight to race, class, gender, *and* sexuality as aspects of organizational structure and bases for inequalities among workers.

Gendering in context

In a comprehensive review and critique of the theory of gendered organizations and studies drawing on the perspective, Britton (2000) argues that the key to using the approach effectively is an acute awareness of the importance of organizational context. In making this argument, Britton is critiquing studies of gendered occupations (in particular) in which organizational contexts tended to be underemphasized or essentially held

constant. For example, it is accurate to say, as Pierce (1995) does, that litigation is a gendered occupation. In her insightful study of lawyers at two firms, Pierce shows that lawyers see themselves as 'Rambo' types, who talk of having 'raped' witnesses or 'seduced' juries. Women litigators must emulate this stereotype to succeed (although norms around femininity set limits on this) – those who do not face a considerable cost. But it is equally true that the organizational context in which work is done shapes the perceptions of workers and the culture of the job. Ely (1995), for example, finds that women in law firms with a relatively high percentage of women partners (admittedly a rarity) hold far less masculinized and stereotyped notions about the traits necessary to succeed, and view their own chances for advancement more positively than their counterparts in firms more dominated by male partners. Hence, the gendering of the job itself, as captured in the seemingly logical equation of masculinity and law in the archetype of the 'Rambo' litigator, can become less rigid in certain organizational contexts. As Britton (2000) notes, understanding what makes some contexts less oppressively gendered than others may be a crucial step in learning how to change organizations for the better.

Recent studies have taken this critique seriously. Some, as we have already noted, highlight issues of intersectionality, locating work and organizations in racialized, classed, or sexualized contexts. Others compare the same work across contexts that differ on other dimensions. One of the best examples is Dellinger's (2004) study of 'safe' and 'embattled' masculinities. In this work, Dellinger looks at workers in the same occupation, accounting, in two very different organizations. One is a feminist magazine, at which men were outnumbered in positions of power and traditional ideas about gender and sexuality were constantly contested. The other is a heterosexual men's pornographic magazine, at which men held positions of power, and workplace tasks and norms were less threatening to traditional masculinity. Accounting itself has long been associated with a rational, calculative middle-class masculinity that prioritizes control, both of the physical world and of the body itself (Burrell 1984; 1987). The job is already gendered; therefore, we might expect that this would produce a particular, and relatively stable, kind of masculinity.

Yet, Dellinger finds that 'where you work matters just as much as what you do' (2004, 546). Men at the feminist magazine constructed a defensive, 'embattled' masculinity at work, one in which they distanced themselves from feminism, derided the magazine's politics as 'bad for business', and engaged in joking among themselves about women and feminism. Men at the pornographic magazine, a 'safe' organizational culture, felt freer to distance themselves from stereotypical heterosexual masculinity, criticize the culture of sexuality promoted by the magazine, and engage in sexual banter with women coworkers. Dellinger's study is powerful because it demonstrates that the very same occupation, performed in different

contexts, produces distinctly contextual masculinities (see also Connell and Messerschmidt 2005).

In a study that extends this analysis to the sexualization of work, Lerum examines norms around sexuality in two organizational contexts, a strip club and a high end restaurant. Feminists have long been suspicious of sexuality in organizations, noting – with considerable evidence and justification – the potential for the exploitation and harassment of women workers by more powerful men. Lerum's work, as well as a number of other studies (e.g., Giuffre and Williams 1994; see also Gherardi 1995), have challenged the traditional feminist critique by demonstrating the embeddedness of sexuality in organizations and the pleasure many workers report they derive from sexualized banter and workplace interactions. Given this apparent contradiction, the most important question then becomes a contextual one; as Lerum puts it: 'Under what conditions is sexuality at work a problem, and for whom?' (2004, 758). Lerum found that women workers were more likely to participate in, and respond positively to, sexuality at work only under certain conditions. In these cases, their enjoyment was linked to a sense of shared cultural assumptions about appropriate behavior, relatively egalitarian power relations, and the need to coordinate work activities very closely. Even so, she found that not all workers had access to sexualized workplace culture – the only employee of color at the restaurant she studied was excluded (and largely excluded himself) from the joking banter engaged in by his coworkers. As we would expect, sexualized workplace cultures are not just gendered, they are raced and classed as well.

Beyond these specific examples, researchers are starting to explore organizational gendering in a wide variety of other settings. Taken together, this body of scholarship defies attempts to generalize about how processes of gendering 'work' in a generic sense. Cadge (2004) has examined processes of gender inequality in Buddhist congregations organized by immigrants versus those in the USA (religion, see also Fobes 2001). Research in the sociology of sport has focused the construction of gender in settings as diverse as golf (McGinnis et al. 2005), cheerleading (Anderson 2005; Grindstaff and West 2006), and gyms for women (Craig and Liberti 2007). Still other work has looked at gendering in macro-contexts, comparing, for example, the influence of urban versus rural settings on women's small business success (Bird et al. 2001; Bird and Sapp 2004), or the role of labor market composition in determining the wage gap (Cohen and Huffman 2003). This may in fact be the fastest growing area of research inspired by a gendered organizations approach. Although studies of gendered organizations that carefully examine the influence of context are central to our understanding of inequalities and organizations, they offer few theoretical generalities. Even so, examining these complexities increases our knowledge of the processes whereby organizations become gendered, raced, classed, and sexualized – as well as the multiple levels at which these processes occur.

Organizational change

In her original statement of a theory of gendered organizations, Acker conceptualized change quite broadly, arguing essentially for the 'end of organizations as they exist today along with a redefinition of work and work relations' (1990, 154–55). As Britton (2000) notes, this notion was tied to Acker's tendency at that stage to view bureaucratic organizations as inherently gendered. Adopting this position requires the development of entirely new organizational forms, 'organizations in which hierarchy is abolished, the work of caretaking is valued as highly as economic production, and the rigid barrier between public and private spheres is dissolved, or at least rendered more permeable' (Britton 2000, 422).

But regardless of the nonbureaucratic organizational forms we can imagine (and for a discussion of alternatives, see Ferree and Martin 1995), change on this scale is a tall order and viewing it in this way has the potential to create paralysis or obscure less sweeping strategies of resistance. Recently, in her treatment of 'inequality regimes', Acker adopts a more strategic vision, suggesting that successful organizational change requires a focus on limited and specific 'inequality-producing mechanisms', 'social movement and legislative' action, and the threat of sanction (Acker 2006, 455). Even so, she recognizes that changes in inequality regimes will be difficult because '[w]hen class identities and interests are integrated with gender and racial identities and interests, opposition may be most virulent to any moves to alter the combined advantages' (Acker 2006, 460). Building on the recent focus on gendering in organizational context, the key issue would then seem to be the identification of those factors that lead to organizational environments that are less oppressive across all of the dimensions of inequality embedded in organizational logics – (minimally) gender, race, class, and sexuality.

One of the most significant challenges to Acker's (1990) early call for an end to bureaucracy as we know it came from the findings of research on formalization in workplace policies. Formal, written policies guiding recruitment, evaluation, and promotion are hallmarks of the classic Weberian bureaucracy. Hence, if organizations were inherently gendered, we might expect that more bureaucratic organizations would be more oppressively gendered than those that relied on less formal criteria. Yet, a large body of research shows that more formal, transparent policies can create more diversity in organizations at all levels. Reskin and McBrier (2000) found that open recruitment, written job descriptions and policies, and transparent evaluation and promotion practices increased the representation of women in management across a representative national sample of 516 business organizations. Similarly, Royster (2003) showed that a reliance on interpersonal networks in recruiting employees for blue-collar jobs led to lower wages and fewer opportunities for African American workers. One certain

mechanism for decreasing inequality in organizations appears to the use of formal, transparent processes.

But one of the great insights of Acker's approach is to highlight the ways that gender and other dimensions of inequality become embedded even in apparently formal, transparent policies and practices – like workplace evaluation policies or job descriptions – that otherwise appear gender neutral. Skuratowicz and Hunter's (2004) study of restructuring in the banking industry is a particularly good example of research directed to understanding the mechanisms through which this happens. In their study of 'bank holding corporation', they show how the creation of two entirely new positions, 'customer relations manager' (CRM) and 'personal banker' (PB) drew on and reinforced gendered inequalities through the bank's practices and assumptions, as well as through workers' own assessment of those cues. Although the overwhelming majority of potential workers in the pool for both positions were women, the bank gender typed the positions from the outset. In their internal promotional materials, the bank denoted the lower paid, lower status of the two positions, the CRM, with a graphic of a woman in a headset. The PB, on the other hand, was depicted as a man in a suit. The CRM's primary responsibility was to sit in a booth at the front of the bank and direct customers; the PB's, to sell financial products at a higher-base salary with a commission. Assumptions about hours of work and responsibilities further gender typed the positions; PBs were expected to work long hours without interruption for family responsibilities. Workers then made choices based on those dimensions, such that in the end the PB position was filled by more men and masculinity (or masculine characteristics) became firmly established as a job requirement. At all levels, the new positions reflected gendered organizational logic, as this quote from a woman PB indicates:

The CRM job is a Wal-Mart greeter. I wouldn't have that job. I would be bored. The customer has no ... respect for the CRM ... because [of] where the CRM is standing – in the booth [a small booth/counter at the entrance to the branch]. Nine times out of 10, if a customer wants to talk to a manager, they want to sit down in an office. They [CRMs] don't get the respect they deserve. (Skuratowicz and Hunter 2004, 102)

Studies like this one are extremely valuable because they demonstrate the mechanisms through which gender becomes a part of organizational logic and over time comes to seem only natural. It is at such moments of change that the processes engendering organizations are most visible, and hence most vulnerable to challenge.

Still other work has examined how workers themselves participate in processes that exacerbate gender inequality. McGuire (2002), for example, shows that even when women managers occupy the same organizational level and command the same resources, they receive less assistance from their informal networks. She attributes this to a process of ranking among

workers in which they come to value some ties as more important than others. Given the importance of these informal networks in organizations, women who try to use formal pathways to achieve goals like promotion may be viewed as 'losers' who do not understand the system. She writes, '[w]omen, in effect, face a double-edged sword. They obtain less instrumental help than men do from their informal network members, but if they turn to formal outlets ... they risk being further marginalized' (2002, 318–19). Hence, what this study demonstrates is that changes in formal policies and access to management positions are not enough – changes in the status beliefs of workers themselves may be necessary to deal with entrenched inequalities.

Taken together, the work on organizational change does not perhaps lead us to particularly optimistic conclusions. We can be certain that some policies, especially those that encourage transparency and formalization, are steps in the right direction. But the rapidly multiplying body of research on mechanisms that produce inequality at work tells us that inequalities of gender, race, class, and sexuality are deeply entrenched in workplace cultures, interactions, and even the identities of workers. Before change strategies are identified or implemented, inequality processes must be made visible. To this end, we cannot merely note the consequences of working within gendered organizations or the characteristics of gendered organizations, we must see the processes whereby organizations maintain and reproduce inequalities. Looking at the intersections of gender, race, class, and sexuality, as well as organizational context are central to making inequalities visible – as we have suggested. More research directed at understanding the specific mechanisms through which inequalities are reproduced can only help us to identify strategies for real and enduring change.

Conclusion – Prospects for a theory of gendered organizations

If the explosion of scholarship in the area is any indication, the trend toward understanding gender, race, class, and sexuality as aspects of the social structure – rather than individual traits – now seems quite solidly established. Since her original statement of the theory, scholarship has deepened and challenged some parts of Acker's vision, demonstrating the importance of multiple axes of inequality, exploring contextual differences across organizations, and discovering mechanisms for change. And perhaps in response, Acker's perspective has itself shifted toward a more nuanced view, one that increasingly considers intersectionality.

As an approach, the 'theory' of gendered organizations is perhaps less a theory – in the sense of the classic definition of theory as a set of testable hypotheses – as it is a framework for seeing inequality. And in that it has been enormously valuable, drawing the attention of scholars to the ways that gender inequality persists even in the face of apparent pressures (like

the increasing human capital of women, or cultural norms that pay lip service to women's equality) toward change. Our guess is that research employing the gendered organizations perspective (or some version of it) will continue along all of the lines we have discussed here, and our hope is that this empirical work continues to complicate our view of how inequalities are both built into social structures and reproduced by them. And indeed our understanding of gender, race, class, and sexuality in organizations and occupations is already far richer as a result of the diverse work of the last two decades.

Short Biographies

Dana M. Britton's research focuses on gender, work, social control, sexualities, and social history. She is the author of *At Work in the Iron Cage: The Prison as Gendered Organization* (New York University Press, 2003) and the editor of collection *Gender and Prison* (Ashgate Press, 2005). She has published papers based on her research in *Gender & Society*, *Criminology*, *The Sociological Quarterly* and other academic journals. Britton is currently Professor of Sociology at Kansas State University and editor of the journal *Gender & Society*. She holds a PhD in Sociology from the University of Texas at Austin.

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